



# The Scary Truth About Labels

2022 // Dennie Declercq // Kansas City Developers Conference

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# Who am I?

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- Dennie Declercq
- Passionate Developer
- President & IT-coach DDSoft
- Microsoft MVP
- Mr. #DreamingIsBelieving





# (or) Who Am I?

- Dennie Declercq
- Autistic
- Jobless
- Volunteer
- Man
- Single
- Not a graduate



# Who Am I? Revisited

- Dennie
- A person
- A unique living being

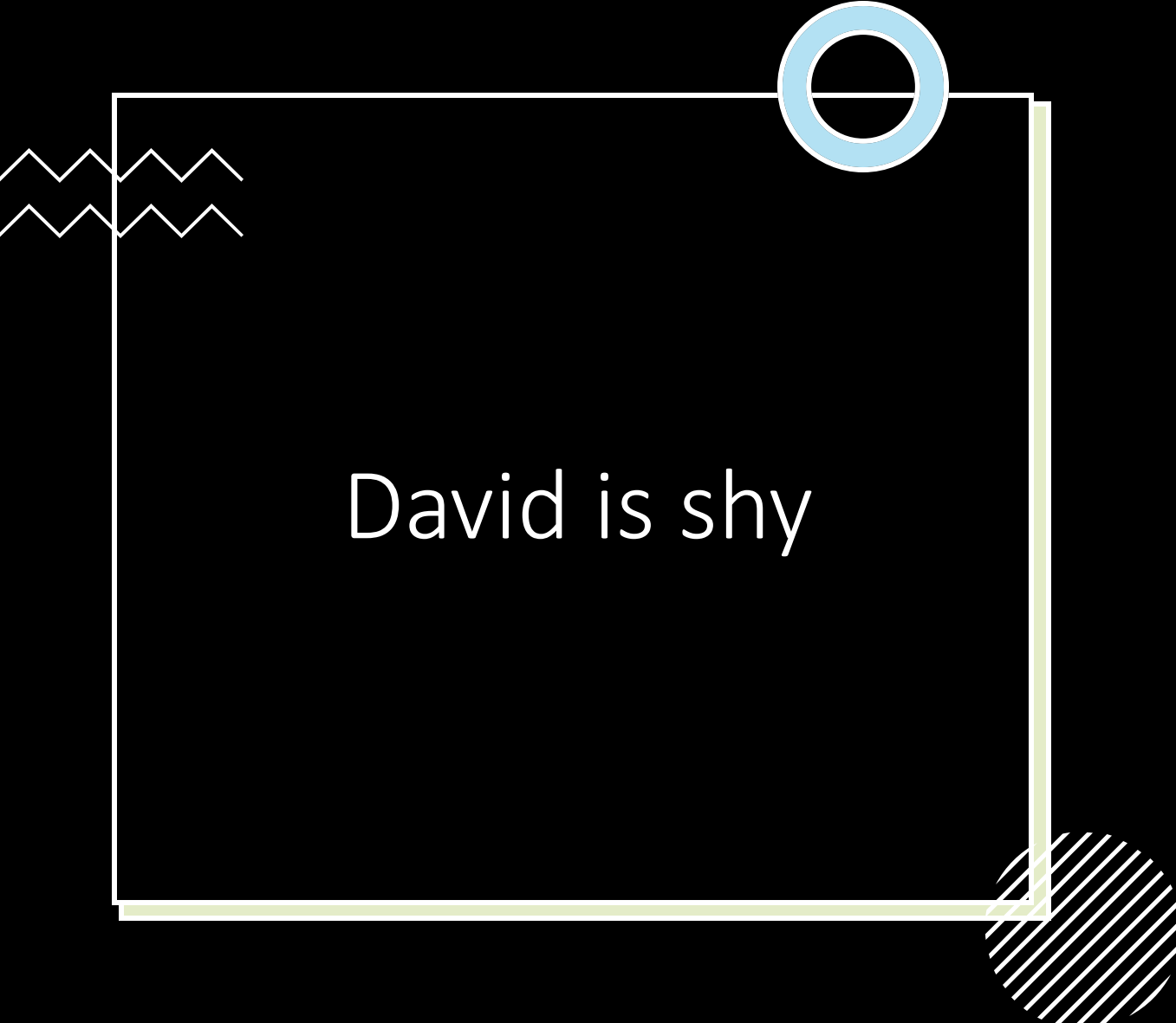


Scary Labels

# Let's talk about Lisa

- She's not masculine
  - She is not a graduate
  - What the opportunities are didn't she had
  - She's not a math engineer
- She is clever
  - She is self-thought
  - Lisa has unique views
  - Lisa is unique
  - Lisa found a way to program in C++
    - With a self-made work around math

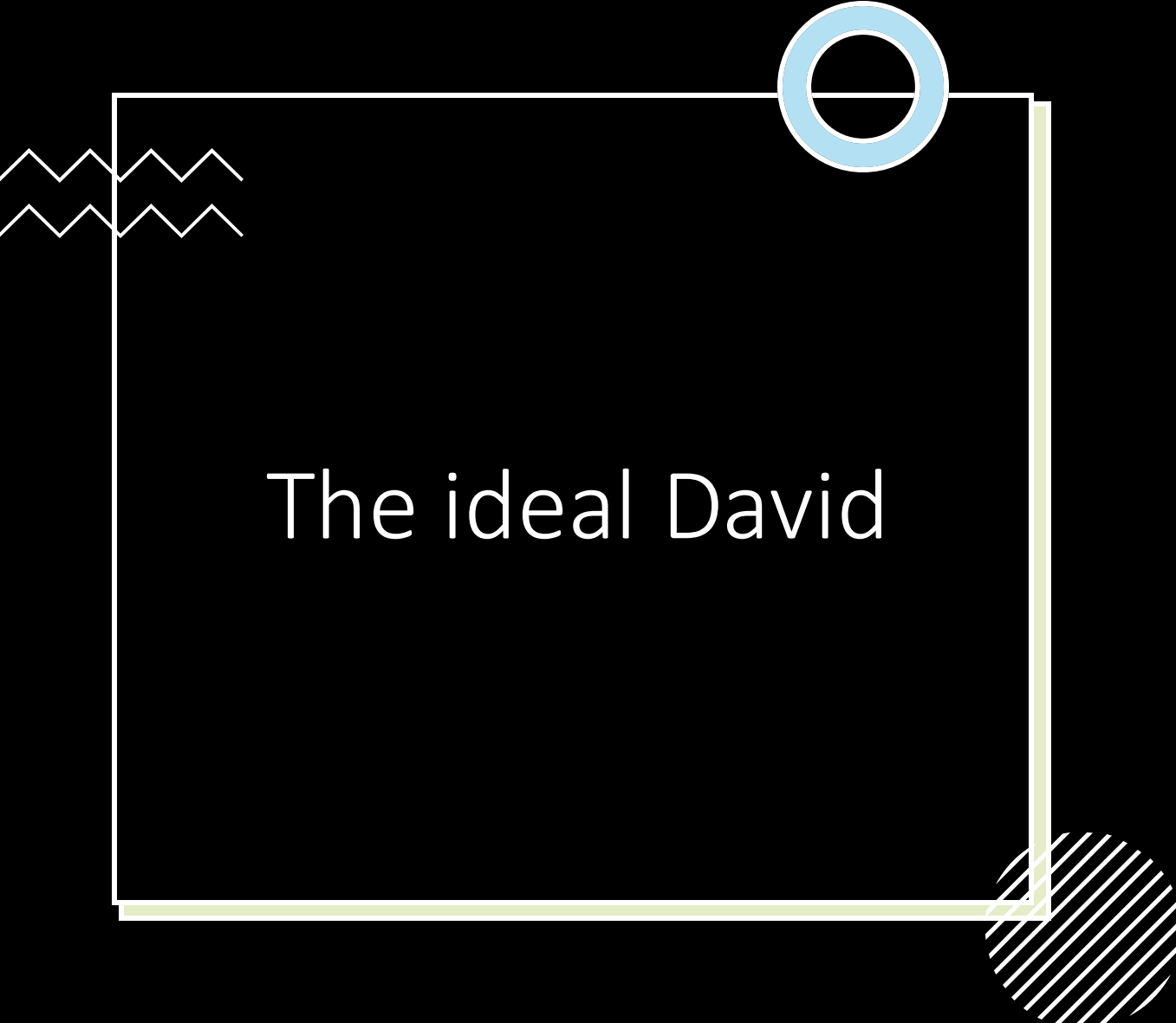
What can Lisa do vs what can't she do?



David is shy

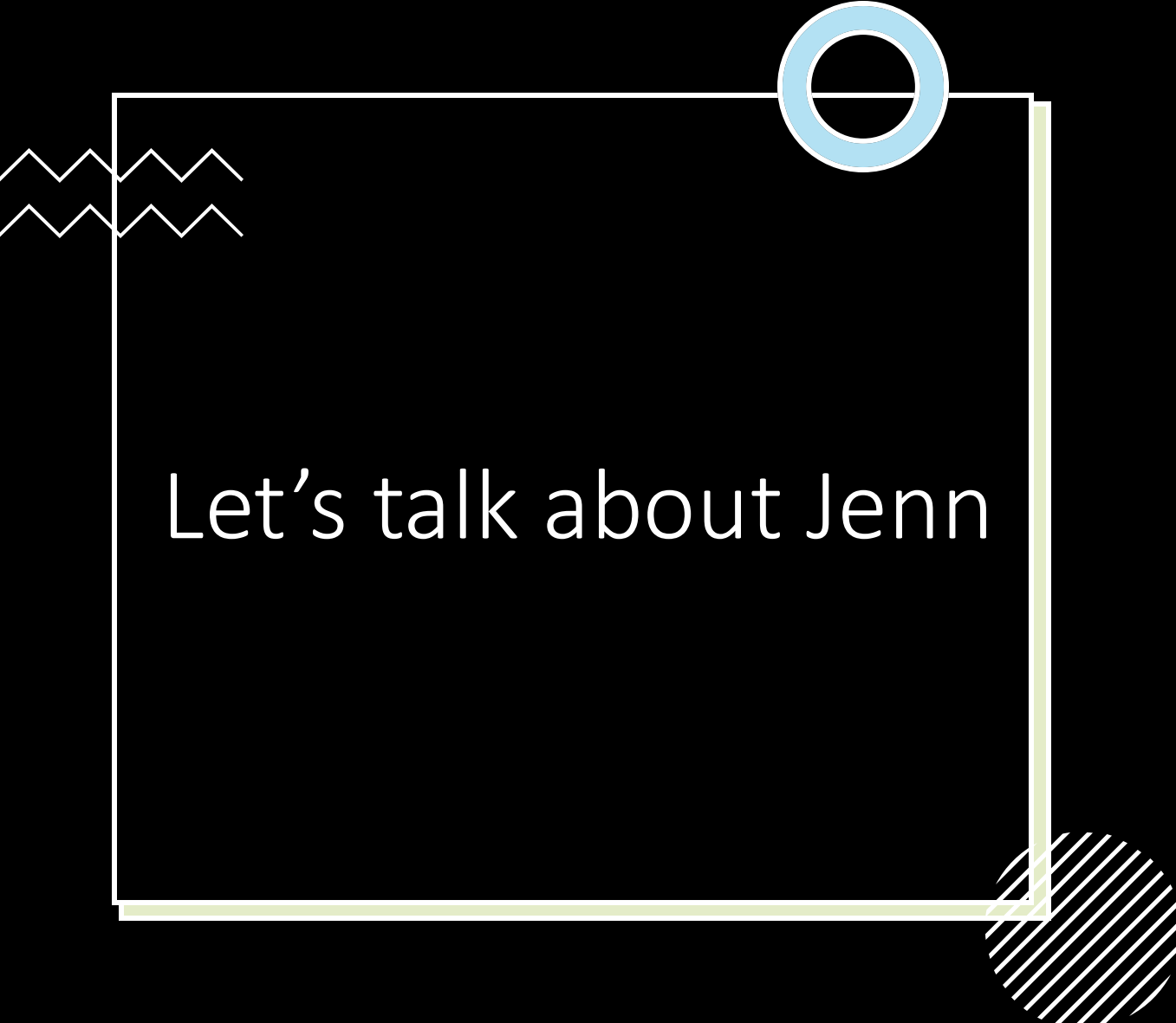
- He needs to do a job;
  - In a factory
  - In a group
  - He doesn't belong
  - He is bullied for being weird
- In his free time;
  - He draws the nicest drawings
  - He can't sell them
  - He throws them away
- He is not allowed to sell this, because he couldn't start a business.





# The ideal David

- Sells his drawings.
- Focussed full day on drawing.
- People, fabrics, bars, hotels, streets
  - Enlightened with David's talent



Let's talk about Jenn

- Jenn is 17.
- Jenn has a learning disability.
- She has over protecting parent's.
- She can't do what her friends do.



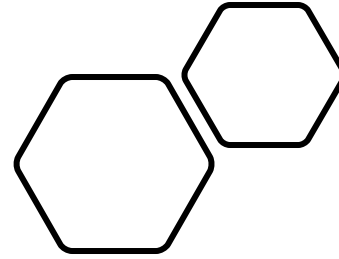
Label: Normal

- Can do everything
- Lives healthy
- Eats healthy
- Indicates borders and limits
  - But goes a lot over own borders
- Has well-paid job
- Has 2 kids: a boy and a girl
- Has a hobby



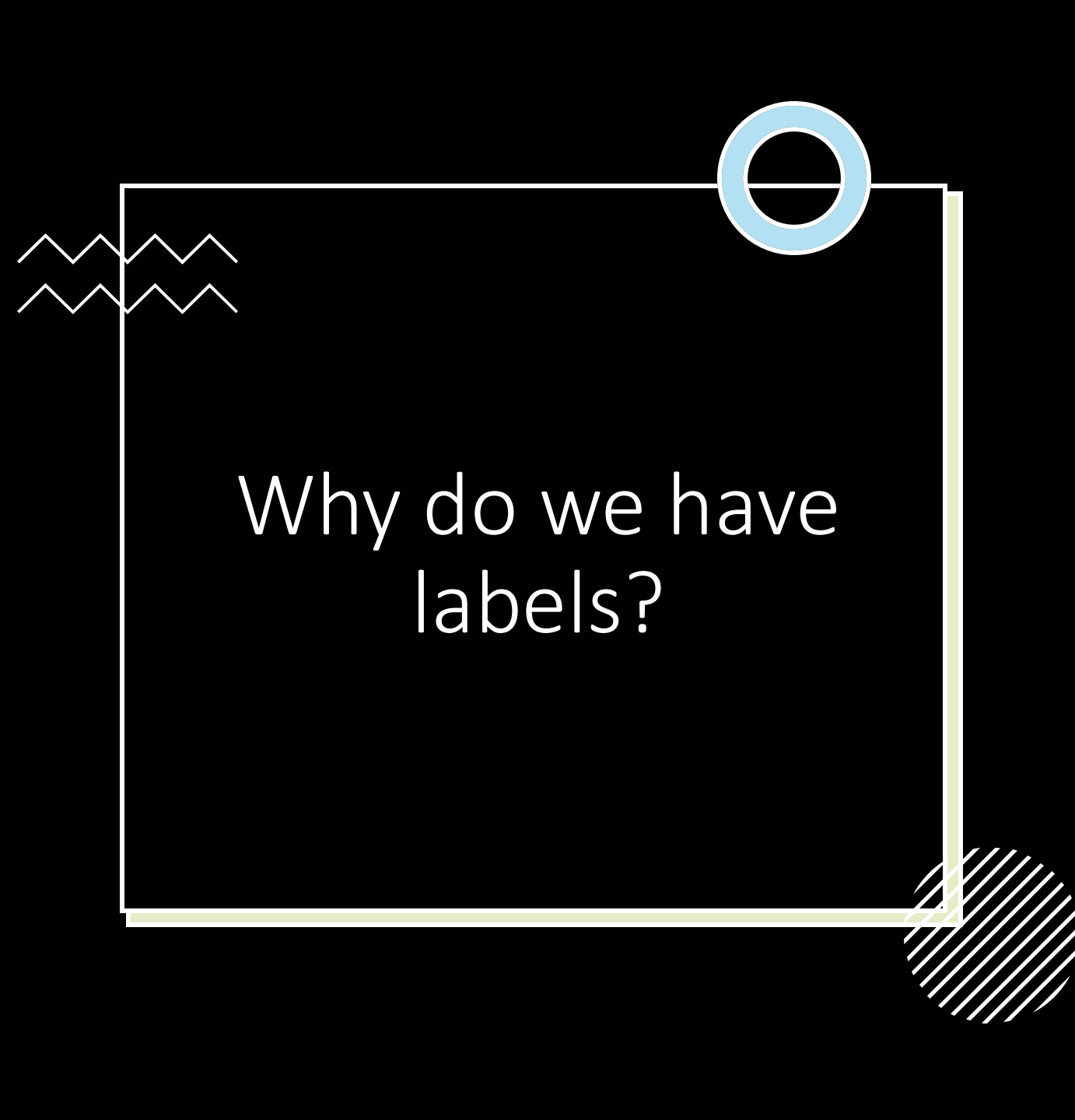
How many people do  
you know?

How many  
people don't  
dare to talk  
about



Their differences





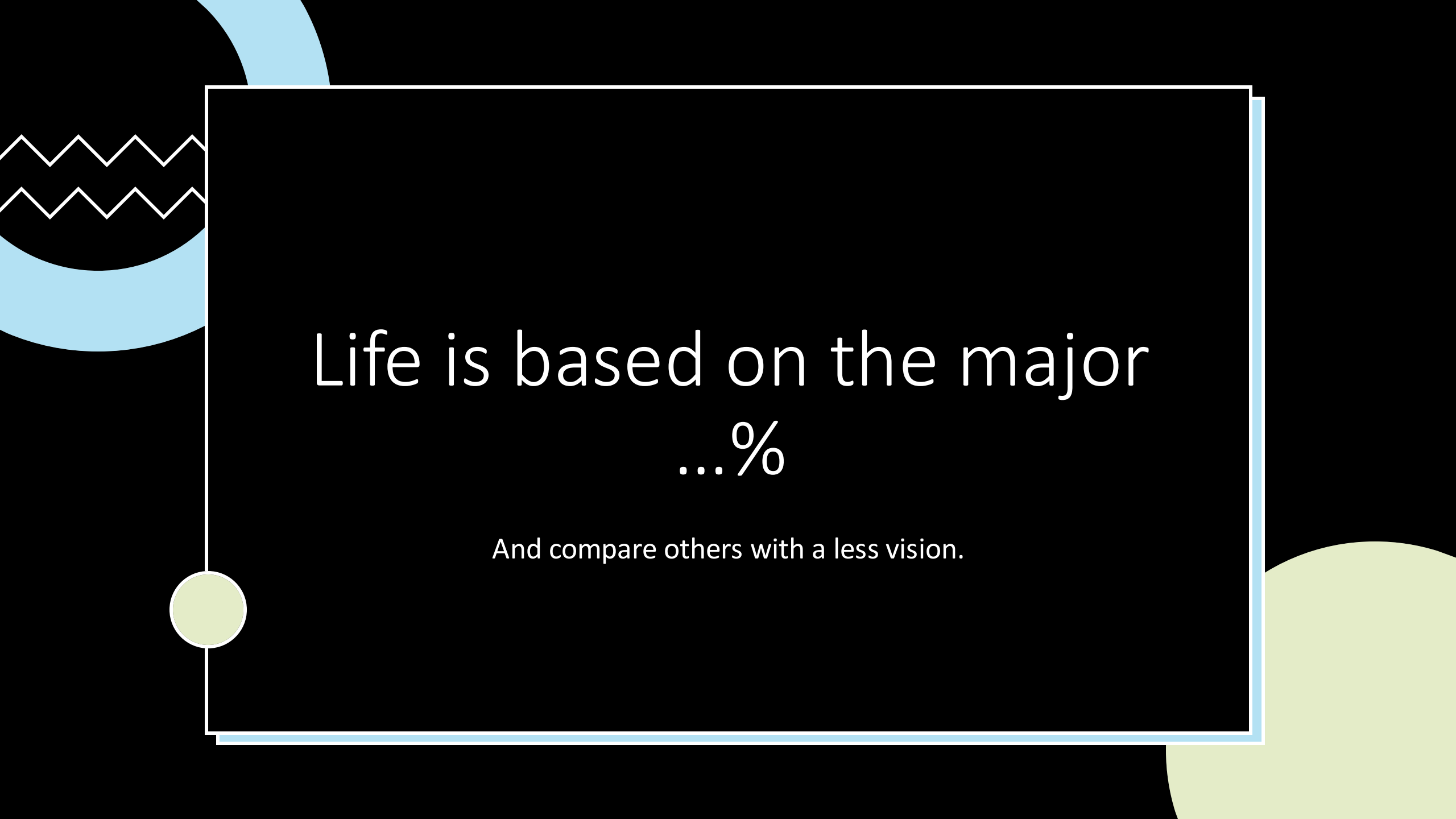
Why do we have  
labels?

- Legacy
- Grouping of people
- Budgets are based on groups
- Funds are based on groups
- Regulations are based on groups



We de-individualised  
people

- But put them in labels and regions!



Life is based on the major  
...%

And compare others with a less vision.

# Labels excludes other labels

**OR**

- Man
- Left-handed
- 'Paid' job
- Tech-savy
- Engineer
- Smart
- Geek

**OR**

- Woman
- Right-handed
- Jobless
- (complete) Tech noob
- Spiritual
- Dumb
- Social

# We need to make choices

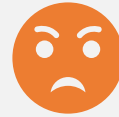
**OR**

- Eating healthy
- Sitting job
- Being rich
- Study

**OR**

- Eating tasty
- Standing job
- Working (less/ not paid)
- Starting young helping the family

# We learned



To sacrifice



If we belong to a label

We need to live completely as 'on the label'

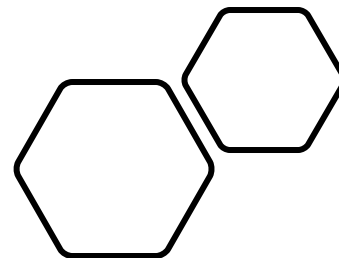


The label 'normal' is the label to go for



We need to make trade-offs

# We identify

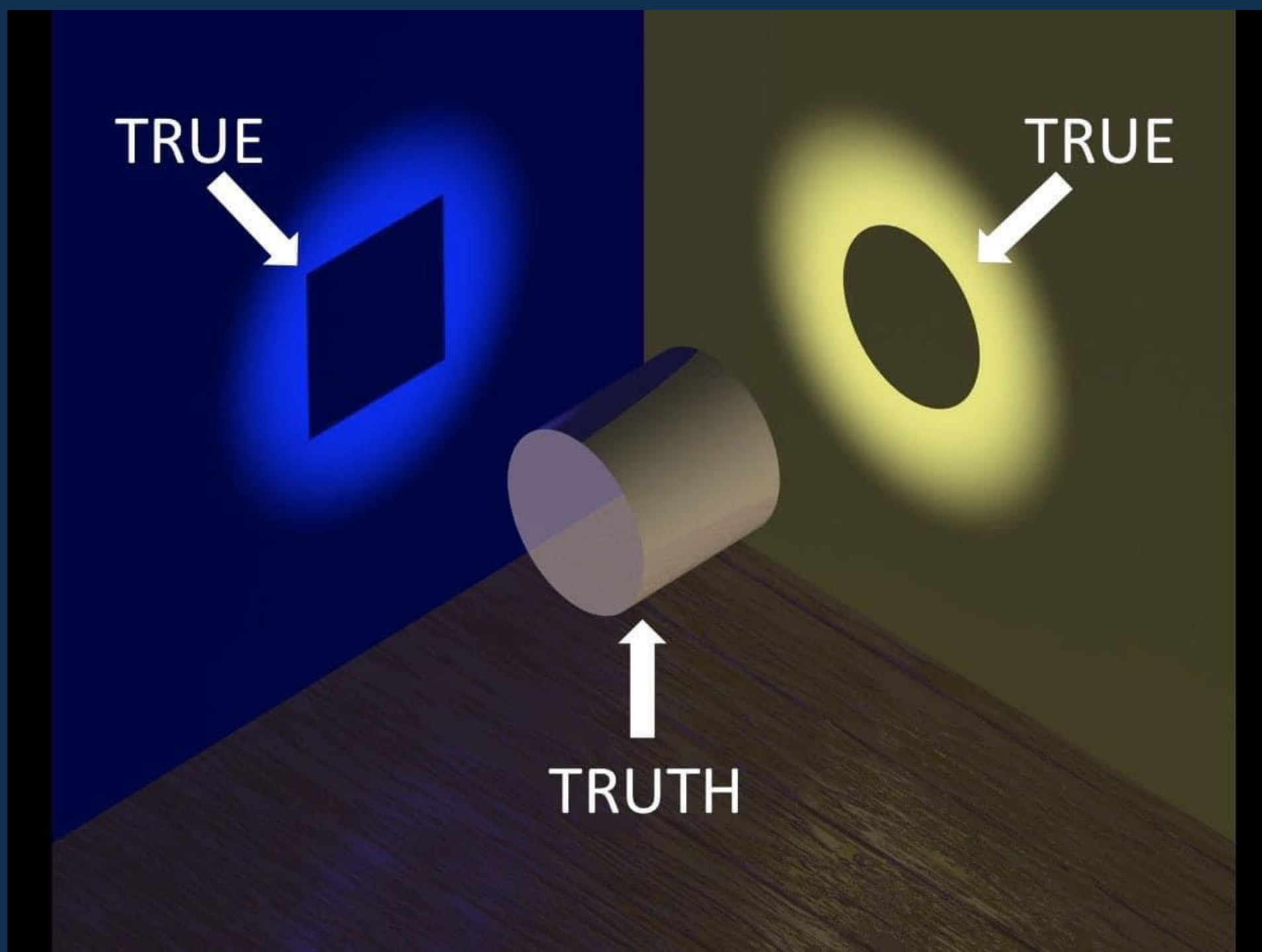


Or do we get identified?











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# It's pseudo science!

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## From today's featured article



Reconstructed skeleton of *Thalassodromeus*

***Thalassodromeus*** was a pterosaur (a flying reptile) that lived in what is now northeastern Brazil about 100 million years ago, during the **Early Cretaceous**. The original skull was discovered in 1983 in the **Romualdo Formation** of the **Araripe Basin**. This **genus** had one of the largest known skulls among pterosaurs, around 1.42 metres (4 ft 8 in) long, with one of the

largest cranial crests of any **vertebrate** in proportion to its skull. Running from the tip of the upper jaw to beyond the **occiput** at the back of the skull, the lightly built crest may have been used for **thermoregulation** or in **display behaviour**. The crest may not have fully developed until after sexual maturity. Though only the skull is known, the animal is estimated to have had a **wingspan** of 4.2 to 4.5 m (14 to 15 ft). The jaws were toothless, with sharp upper and lower edges and strong musculature. *Thalassodromeus* may have been able to kill and eat prey on the ground. (**Full article...**)

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## In the news

- In cycling, Jonas Vingegaard (*pictured*) wins **the Tour de France**.
- The World Health Organization declares **the monkeypox outbreak** a public health emergency of international concern.
- The **Chinese paddlefish**, one of the world's largest freshwater fish species, is declared **extinct** by the International Union for Conservation of Nature.
- Amid protests over the economic crisis, Ranil Wickremesinghe **is elected** President of Sri Lanka by the parliament.



Jonas Vingegaard

**Ongoing:** [COVID-19 pandemic](#) • [Russian invasion of Ukraine](#)  
**Recent deaths:** [Tony Dow](#) • [Henry Janzen](#) • [Paul Sorvino](#) • [Chin Kung](#) • [David Trimble](#) • [Tim Giago](#)

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# The next part of my talk

- Work-Life
- (Mental) Health
- Gender & More
- One More thing...
- How to live with those labels
- Thanks/ Q&A



Work-Life





# Time/ Location

- Working
  - 80% - 20%
  - Day – Night
  - 90% - 10%
- What is time anyway?
- From home
  - 20% - 80%
  - 10% - 90%
  - 50% - 50%

The real question is:  
Where and When are you most productive?

# Paid job – volunteer job

- What if your personal money source isn't from your work/ job?
- What if you get a free from the government?
- What if your partner works a lot, and you are completely agree with this.
- What if your back is rubbish before the age of 50?

- Paid Job
  - I use the term 'normal-paid-job', a job in a company (or as CEO) or organization.
  - You get salary (in return for your soul – oh yes, this is taboo).
- Volunteer job
  - You earn no money for your work.
  - Free will, mission and thrive is the reason.
  - Majority of folks (90+%) do this next to their job and/ or studies.

If people talking about a job it's always a paid job: research papers, CONFERENCE REGISTRATION...  
Is this separation and labeling really needed?



# What's your degree?

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- The workplace and **professional** space are focussed a lot on a college or university college degree.
- I know people that have way more experience, knowhow and thrive from the field.

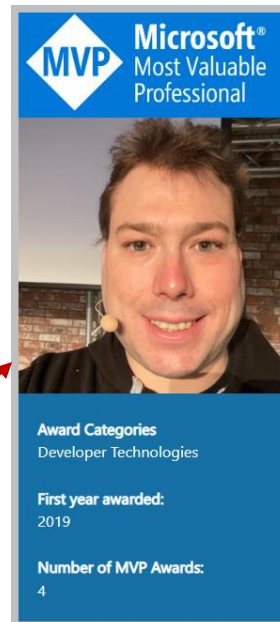
BTW: '**Professional**' is a very scary word:

**Professional** comes from 'your profession'.

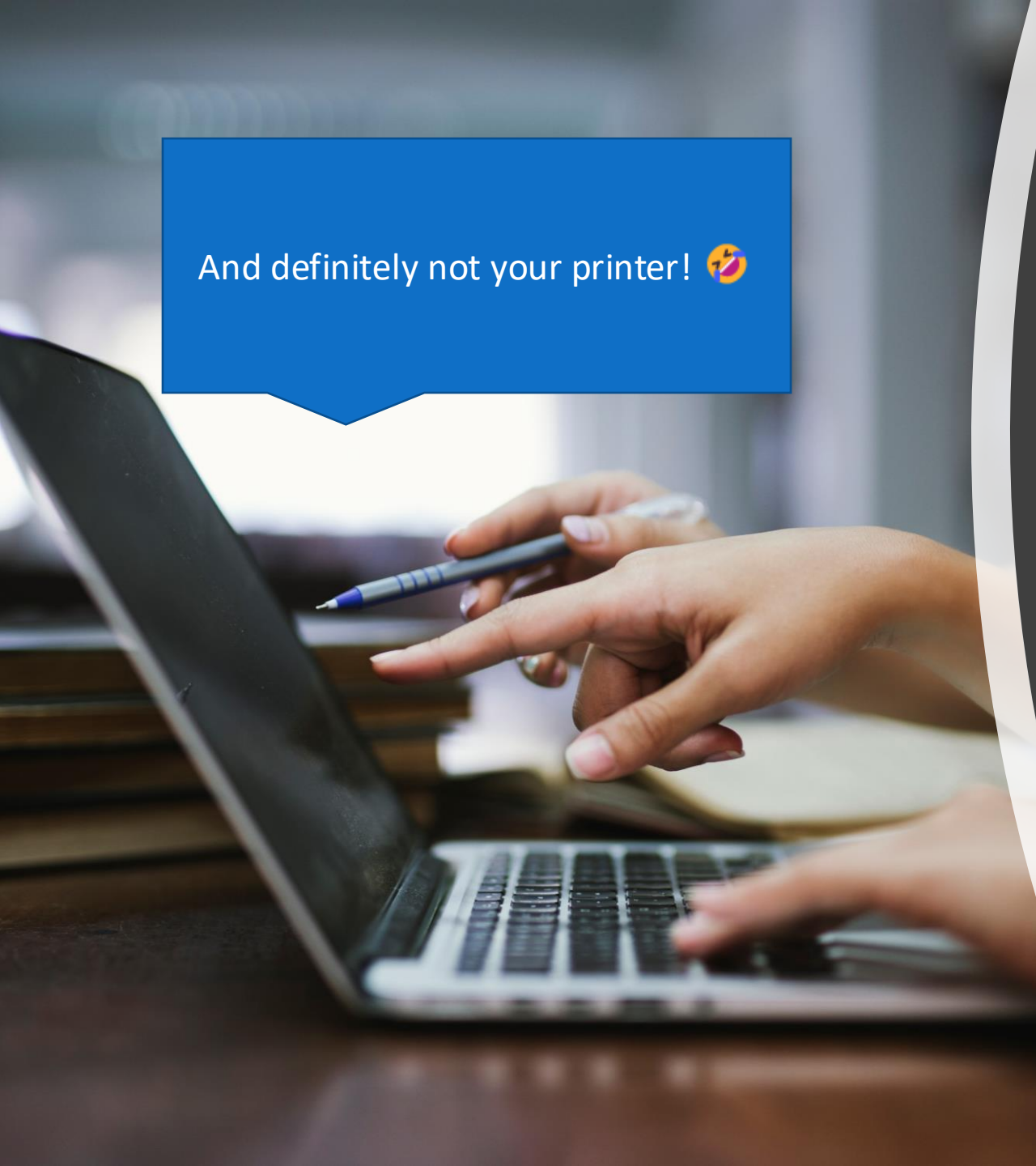
A Profession is directly related to a 'normal paid job'.

Is a amateur, hobbyist less able to preform skills?

**FAKE NEWS on the letter of law and science!**





A close-up photograph of a person's hands interacting with a laptop. One hand is holding a blue pen, pointing at the screen, while the other hand is on the keyboard. A blue callout box with a white border is positioned in the upper left, containing the text 'And definitely not your printer!' followed by a broken with symbol emoji. The background is blurred, showing a desk and some papers.

And definitely not your printer! 🛠️

# Developers don't fix your computer!

- NON-IT people don't understand IT. (Just like we don't understand their field of industry).
- (Web) Designers, Developers, Programmers, Computer Fixers, Hackers, Crackers, Computer makers... Are all the same
- How do we cope this? How do we say:
  - I can't ...
  - I don't ...
  - I am not willing to ...

Those are labels only understood by a minority\*

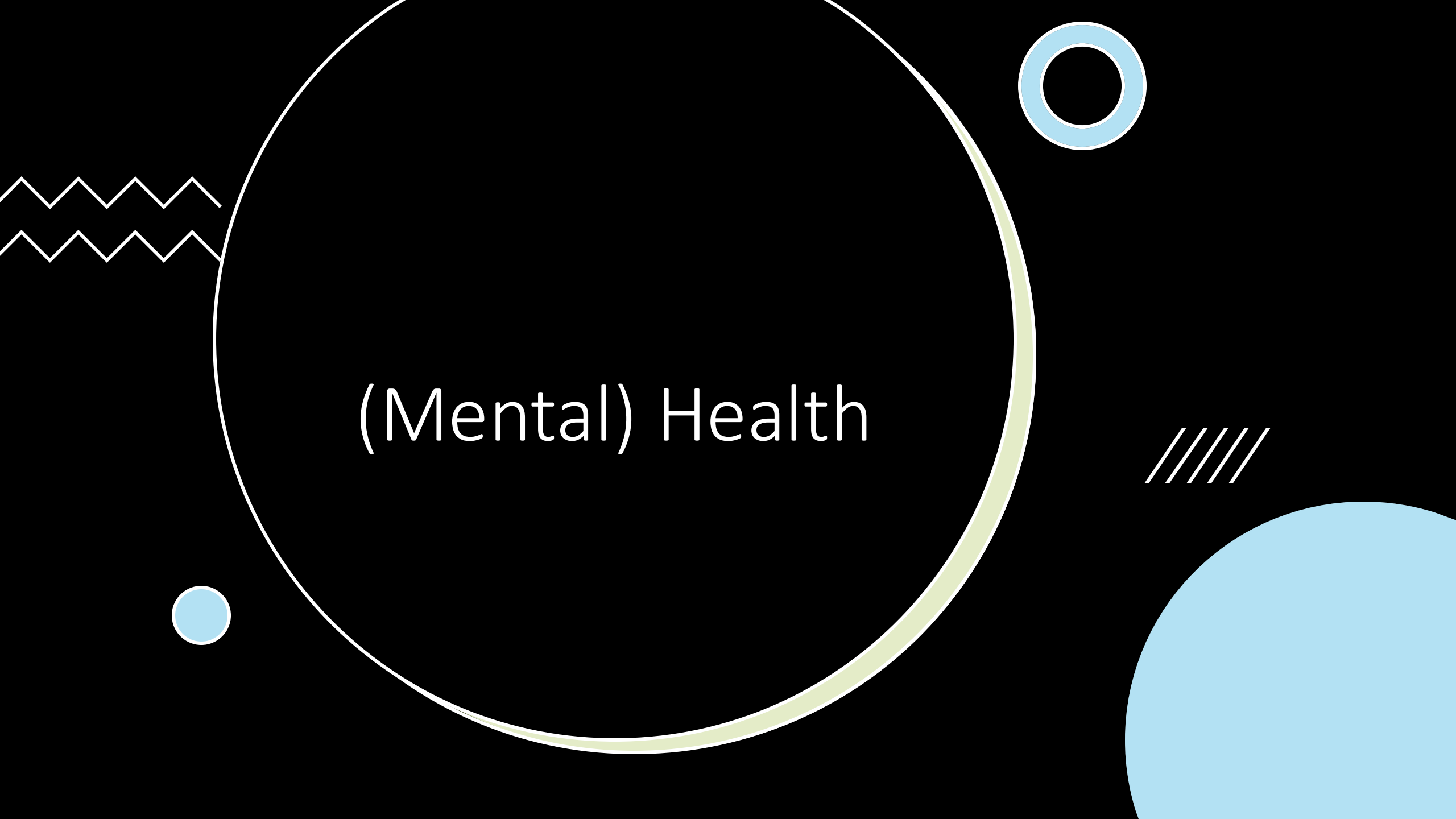
\* = over the whole world and all industries



# I am a .NET Developer!

- Do .NET developers use JavaScript?
- Do .NET developers use Python for Machine Learning?
- Do .NET developers use C for Arduino stuff?
- Do .NET developers use Java?
- And vice versa!

We are way more the same than we think!

The image features a dark navy blue background. A large, thin white circle is centered, with a thick, light green double-line arc following its right side. To the left of the circle, two white zigzag lines extend from the edge. Below the circle, a small light blue circle is positioned. To the right of the circle, a light blue ring is located in the upper right, and a set of four parallel white diagonal lines is in the middle right. A large, solid light blue circle is partially visible in the bottom right corner.

(Mental) Health

# Just be normal

---

- People are used to hide their mental worries.
- People are learned to preform.
- Work hard, play hard!
- People are measured about their achievements. The more, the better.
- “Drama is for TV”, “Your home is home, work is work”.
- We learned: “Indicate our limits and borders” with the unwritten law: “But go over it A LOT”.

Of course, knowing that there is more work for less people. And that people need to work more than in the past, in combination with the rules above.. We are still surprised there's so much burn out. “They don't want!!”

---

# If I can do it...

---

- If I am autistic and can work in a fabric, you are...
- If I am 50yo and do labour work, you...
- If I understand to solve this math problem, you...
- If I don't travel with planes because of climate, you...
- If I am not afraid of, you...
- If I am afraid of, you...
- If I believe in, you...



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# Yeah but **they** are saying...

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- ... That it's possible to work full time if you are autistic.
- ... That it's bad to code in C#, because C++ is faster.
- ... That Climate Activists do this because it's needed for the future.
- ... That it's not possible to be an MVP without a paid job.
- ... That there are only a limited amount of people that ...
- .. That medication is ...

OK, who are '**they**'?  
Did **you** research?  
What's **your** feeling?  
What's **your** opinion?

---

But this  
(don't)  
works for  
me! So....

---

- I tried to build this in .NET and it didn't work, so you...
- I build this in my free time, so you...
- I don't watch TV at nights because it's waste of time, so you...
- I went to a psychiatrist for this, so you...
- I tried a unproven paramedic technique and it didn't work, so you...
- A conference has too many stimuli for me, so you...
- I can't go out because I am too anxious, so you...

---

In the past  
there  
was/were  
no....

---

- Absenteism
- Autism
- ADHD
- Burnout
- Transgenders
- Long depressions

To be honest you are right!

But also: less people on the planet, shorter career lifetime, 'retards' in institutions, more family drama,  
Less scientific knowledge, more unknown abuse,...

The image features a large, thin white circle centered on a black background. Inside this circle, the text "Gender & More" is written in a white, sans-serif font. To the left of the circle, there are two horizontal wavy lines. Above the circle, there is a small blue circle with a white outline. To the right of the circle, there is a larger blue circle with a white outline. In the bottom right corner, there is a large, solid blue circle. Additionally, there are several diagonal white lines in the bottom right area and a small blue circle with a white outline in the top right area.

Gender & More

# Male & Female jobs

## Wrong

- We need males in each job/industry
- We need females in each job/industry
- Males need to work
- Females need to work

## Right

- Males & Females need to feel safe at work.
- Discrimination on gender is not OK.
- Males & Females need to get the same opportunities.
- Males & Females need to be able to do the job that they want.
- Males & Females need to be paid the same money for the same job!



# Male & Female schools

Mixed schools or separate schools?

Can we have a global vision? Is this realistic?

If person A disagrees, and person B agrees?

- Is there a right or wrong?
- Is the one better than the other?

It's true that mixed schools will cause more mixed job opportunities and markets.

AGAIN: kids feeling them SAFE and get opportunities in their safe environment if the MOST IMPORTANT

# Sexual orientation // Experimentation

Being LGBTQ+ is  
really OK.

Being straight is  
really OK.

Most of the middle-  
aged people don't  
understand LGBTQ+  

- Gay/ Lesbian was easier.

Not understanding  
everything is OK

More than the  
majority of times:  
there's no bad intent  
by others.

Education, speaking,  
interest in the other  
is KEY

# In the past everything was binary!

- I see a lot of middle age people (50+) really not understanding the 'non-binary' gender.
- I understand and agree the non-binarity.
- I do understand the world is changing too fast for middle-aged people.
- We know that media has an opinionated view.
- What you don't know, feel or recognize is not there. This is humane
- We need to open the conversation on a non-violent way.
- Gender things are even a broader topic: "Story 2020: Dennie at the local market"



# One More Thing...

One more Label



# Trigger Warning

I promised the SCARY truth. I make my promise



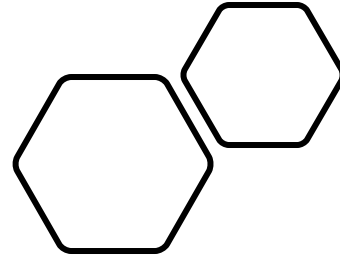




The image features three large, overlapping circles on a solid black background. The top-left circle is orange, the bottom-left circle is teal, and the right circle is blue. Each circle has a thin, light gray border. The blue circle on the right contains the text "How to live with those labels?" in a white, sans-serif font.

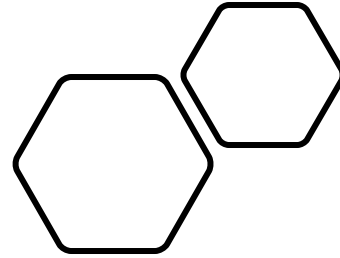
How to live with  
those labels?

# Think outside the box

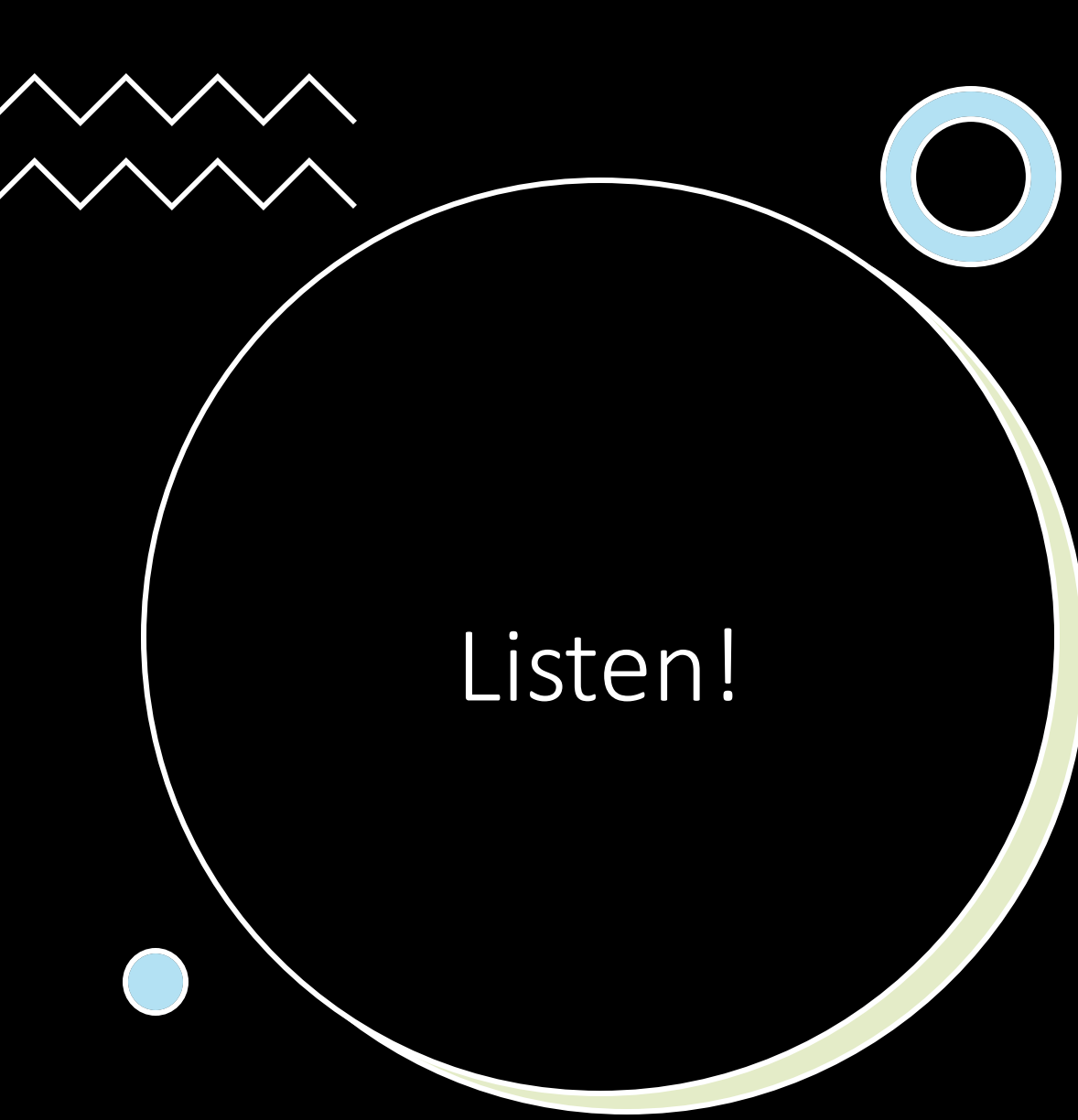


- Think thru the labels
- Think and-and instead of or-or
- Being whole (my friend Dux Raymond Sy @meetdux)

# Boxes? Labels?



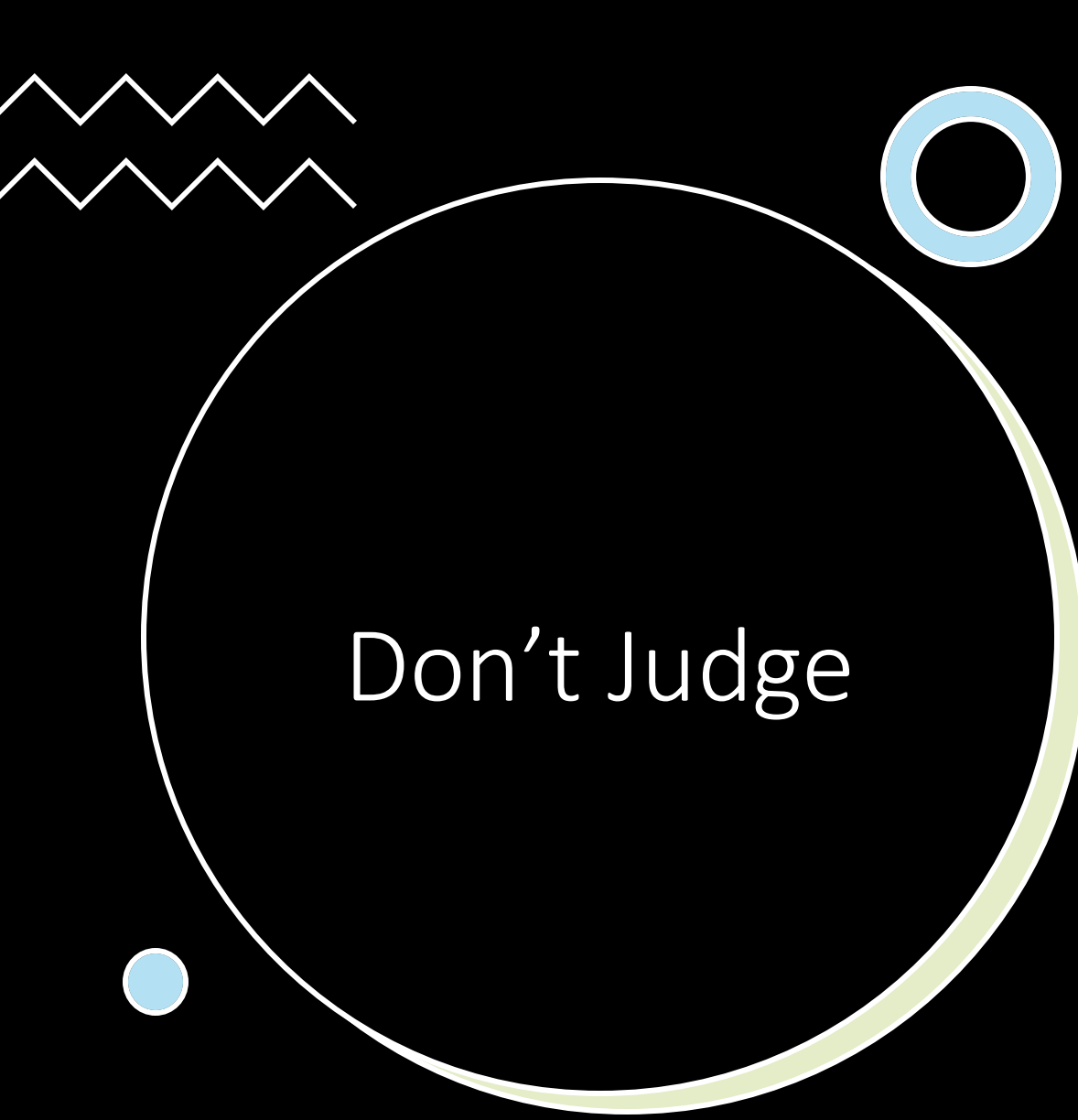
- A coder with a spiritual passion
- A famous cook who is vegetarian (but cooking meat for customers)
- A girl clothed as a man
- A coder with a lack of math
- An MVP without a job



# Listen!

- Connect with real people, unique identities of the “label groups”.
- Ask open questions.
- Listen open minded.
- Ask further.
- Research on blogs/ vlogs/ podcasts from people in the ‘label groups’.
- Indicate your borders & limits AND follow them!
- Non – violent communication is key.
- Be curious (Sorry: @quorralyne)!





# Don't Judge

- Judges in the court judge people.
  - People don't need to do judging.
  - If I am right, it's not automatical that your wrong.
  - Everyone has his/ her/ they own background.
    - Their own mental back-pack
  - It's OK to disagree.
- 

# Know: (Social) Media, not that black and white

- Media is opinated to certain point.
- A lot of people on social media, don't invest time to get knowledge
  - Only speak from own perspective
- If we ban topic from popular accessible social media
  - The people are going underground
  - Know that underground social media is really accessible in the 2020's
- People Science: People search and need belonging
- A label can be an excuse to dig deeper into dark places





Q&A



Thanks !  
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